

Necessitism and eternalism

Handout for *Time and Modality* seminar
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1 Necessitism and contingentism

(NE) $\forall x \Box \exists y (y = x)$.

(NNE) $\Box \forall x \Box \exists y (y = x)$.

- Unrestricted quantification
- Warning about ‘exist’

Putative counterexample to NE: It could have been that Elizabeth and Philip never met; If Elizabeth and Philip had never met, nothing would have been identical to Charles; So, it could have been that nothing was identical to Charles.

Williamson’s response: deny second premise on unrestricted reading of quantifier. But agree that if E and P had never met, no flesh-and-blood person would have been identical to Charles. Charles would not even have been a physical object; he would have been ‘non-concrete’.

2 NE and counterpart theory

NE follows both from BMCT and from Lewis’s counterpart theory.

- In the case of Lewis’s theory but not BMCT, this goes along with a weird failure of the K axiom.

What is the correct counterpart-theoretic interpretation of the modal formulas of the standard language of quantified modal logic? —Who cares? We can make them mean whatever we like. We are their master. We needn’t be faithful to the meanings we learned at mother’s knee—because we didn’t. If this language of boxes and diamonds proves to be a clumsy instrument for talking about matters of essence and potentiality, let it go hang. Use the resources of modal realism *directly* to say what it would mean for Humphrey to be essentially human, or to exist contingently. (*OPW* 12–13)

Suggestion: modal counterpart theorists should embrace NE and not worry about whether this conflicts with common sense. And they should embrace Williamson’s ontology of contingently ‘non-concrete’ things, since this provides the best account of the putative counterexamples.

3 Eternalism and temporaryism

(EE) $\forall x H \exists y (y = x)$

$\forall x G \exists y (y = x)$

Why the standard B-theory

4 ‘Actualism’ and ‘presentism’

Actualism: ‘Everything is actual’.

- Note: Fine thinks actualism so defined is obviously false, but holds that everything *real* is actual.

In English, the adjective ‘actual’ almost always combines with a noun or noun phrase, as in ‘This is an actual problem’ or ‘It could have happened that every actual philosopher was a poet’. In these uses it seems ‘non-intersective’: e.g. ‘actual philosopher’ does not mean ‘thing that is actual and a philosopher’. So what does ‘actual’ mean on its own? And does the thesis that everything is actual even rule out accepting NE?

- Problem: ‘Everything is actual’ seems to entail ‘Every world is actual’, which seems crazy. Standard response is to distinguish two senses of ‘actual’, one of which only applies to worlds etc. .

Presentism: ‘Everything is present’.

‘Present’ has more of a life as a bare adjective than ‘actual’. Most obviously, we can characterise *times* as present or non-present. However, many presentists think that ‘There are non-present times’ has a true reading, involving a different sense of ‘present’ from the one in presentism. Somewhat less naturally, we can characterise *events* as present, where this is roughly equivalent to ‘occurring’. We can also talk about people as present, but this seems to be a spatial sense that is not the intended one.

5 Higher-order necessitism and contingentism

- (1) a. Necessarily, every proposition is necessarily identical to some proposition.
b. Necessarily, every property is necessarily identical to some property.
- (2) a. $\Box\forall P\Box\exists Q(Q = P)$
b. $\Box\forall F\Box\exists G(G = F)$
- (3) a. $\Box\forall P\Box\exists Q(\Box(Q \equiv P))$
b. $\Box\forall F\Box\exists G(\Box\forall x\Box(Gx \equiv Fx))$

Does the existence of a haecceity for a thing entail the existence of the thing?

$$\Box\forall F(\Diamond\exists x(\Box\forall y\Box(Fy \equiv y = x)) \rightarrow \exists xFx)$$

Problem: knives, blades and handles.

Should first-order contingentists be higher-order contingentists?

- One argument turns on a conception of propositions and properties as ‘structured entities’. Is there another?

Challenge for higher-order contingentists: formulate defensible general *necessary* conditions for higher-order existence.

6 Williamson’s objection to higher-order contingentism

- (1) The proposition that I don’t exist is such that: necessarily, if I don’t exist, it is true.
- (2) The proposition that I don’t exist is such that: necessarily, if it is true, it exists.
- (3) So, the proposition that I don’t exist is such that: necessarily, if I don’t exist, it exists.